within three days on the issue of Tata Sons holding EGM'. In a last-ditch effort, on 2 February, Mistry's family firms moved the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) to restrain the holding company from holding the EGM. However, the next day, the NCLAT rejected Mistry's petition.

On 6 February, Tata Sons held its EGM. While Mistry's family held an 18.4 per cent stake in Tata Sons, Tata Trusts held two-thirds. In addition, part of the remaining shares was with Ratan, Simone Tata, Noel Tata, Jimmy Tata, their relatives Vera Choksey and her brother, and Tata Group companies. Both Cyrus and Shapoor Mistry skipped the EGM but were represented by a team led by Roshan Lentin.

At the EGM, the 'Tata family put up a united front' with both Simone and Noel voting in favour of Ratan. In a press release issued by the holding company, Tata Sons said, 'The shareholders of Tata Sons Limited, at the extraordinary general meeting held today, passed, with the requisite majority, a resolution to remove Mr Cyrus P. Mistry as a Director of Tata Sons Limited.'

But these victories did not bring joy to Ratan, though they did bring relief. He was huddled in regretful contemplation for being forced to remove a chairman of the group for the first time in its 150-year history. He lamented that he was compelled to replace Mistry in a non-Tata way as Mistry had refused to leave. It was a situation that he had not faced before. In the tense atmosphere, there was little that could bring him cheer.

The episode affected his entire being. He gave up on many things he had planned to do in his retirement. He stopped honing his skills on the piano on which, as a student, he had acquitted himself creditably. The books on piano lessons were placed on the cloth cover drawn tightly over the instrument that bore testimony to its unuse. Its keys remained untouched as Ratan grappled with problems more demanding, unexpected though they were.